

Exam Study Guide: Ethics from a Christian Perspective

This guide covers the questions from your notes, providing detailed solutions, structured arguments, and memory aids (mnemonics) to help you ace the exam.

1. Relevance of Studying Ethics from a Christian Perspective

Structure for Essay:

1. **Introduction:** Define Ethics (e.g., The branch of philosophy dealing with human conduct, determining what is right and wrong). State that for Christians, this is rooted in God's nature.
2. **Body:** Discuss the relevance points below in separate paragraphs.
3. **Conclusion:** Summarize how Christian ethics leads to a holistic life honoring God.

Detailed Relevance Points:

- **Moral Guidance:** It provides a clear framework for making decisions. Unlike secular ethics which may change with culture, Christian ethics offers a constant standard (Scripture) for distinguishing right from wrong.
- **Worldview Formation:** It shapes the mind to view the world through "God's lens." It helps believers understand that human worth comes from being made in *Imago Dei* (Image of God), preventing the devaluation of life.
- **Character Building (Virtue):** It moves beyond just "following rules" to transforming the heart. It encourages the cultivation of virtues like patience, love, and honesty (Galatians 5:22-23).
- **Apologetics (Defending the Faith):** In a world of relative truth, it equips Christians to logically defend *why* they believe in absolute moral truths and the sanctity of life.
- **Social Responsibility:** It guides Christians on how to be "salt and light" in society, addressing issues like poverty, corruption, and injustice with a biblical mandate.

Mnemonic: "M-W C-A-S" (My World Class)

- **M** - Moral Guidance
- **W** - Worldview Formation
- **C** - Character Building
- **A** - Apologetics
- **S** - Social Responsibility

2. "No man is an island" (African Traditional Perspectives)

Question: Justify this statement in the context of African Traditional Perspectives on Ethics.

Focus: The communal nature of African life. In Africa, an individual exists only because of the community ("I am because we are").

Detailed Justification:

1. **Farming Together:** Work was not individualistic. Communities engaged in communal labor (e.g., clearing land, harvesting) to ensure food security for everyone, not just the strong.
2. **Conflict Resolution:** Justice was restorative, not just punitive. Elders and the community gathered to settle disputes with the goal of restoring harmony and relationships, rather than just imposing jail time.
3. **Helping the Needy:** There was a built-in social safety net. Orphans, widows, and the elderly were the responsibility of the extended family and the wider clan, ensuring no one was left destitute.
4. **Rites of Passage:** Critical life stages—birth, initiation, marriage, death—were community events. The community witnessed and validated the individual's transition, reinforcing their identity within the group.

 Mnemonic: "C-H-E-F" (The Village CHEF)

- **C** - Conflict Resolution (Restoring harmony)
- **H** - Helping the Needy (Social safety net)
- **E** - Events shared (Rites of passage)
- **F** - Farming Together (Communal labor)

3. Relevance of Ubuntu Ethics in Contemporary Society

Question: Discuss the relevance of Ubuntu Ethics ("I am because we are") today. **Definition:** Stated by **John Mbiti**, Ubuntu emphasizes kindness, humanity, and that our existence is tied to others.

Relevance in Today's World:

- **Promoting Justice:** Ubuntu encourages fairness because harming another is seen as harming oneself.
- **Fostering Unity:** It bridges tribal, political, and social divides by emphasizing common humanity.
- **Ensuring Peace:** It values consensus and reconciliation over conflict.
- **Happiness:** It teaches that true happiness comes from communal well-being, not just personal wealth.
- **Accountability:** Leaders and individuals are answerable to the community, reducing corruption.
- **Responsibility:** It combats the "bystander effect" by making everyone responsible for the welfare of neighbors.
- **Development:** Society grows faster when people collaborate rather than compete destructively.

 Mnemonic: "J-U-M-P H-A-R-D"

- **J** - Justice
- **U** - Unity
- **M** - Mutual Respect (Harmony)
- **P** - Peace
- **H** - Happiness
- **A** - Accountability
- **R** - Responsibility
- **D** - Development

4. Ephesians 5:22-25 (Marriage & Family)

A) Consequences of Failing to Fulfill Roles

When husbands fail to love and wives fail to submit (respect):

- **Divorce:** The ultimate breakdown of the covenant.
- **Disrespect & Misunderstanding:** A cycle of offense where neither party feels valued.
- **Domestic Violence:** Frustration manifesting as physical or emotional abuse.
- **Role Reversal:** Wives forced to take up the husband's responsibilities, leading to **Stress** and burnout.
- **Poor Upbringing:** Children lack stable role models, leading to behavioral issues.
- **Denial of Intimacy:** Withholding affection or sex as punishment, leading to loneliness.
- **Diminished Self-Worth:** Wives feeling unloved and husbands feeling disrespected.
- **Extreme Outcomes:** Suicide or murder arising from deep hopelessness and rage.

🧠 **Mnemonic: "3 D's causing S-S-P"**

- **3 D's:** Divorce, Disrespect/Violence, Denial of intimacy.
- **S:** Stress (Role reversal).
- **S:** Suicide/Murder.
- **P:** Poor Upbringing of children.

B) How Love and Submission Address Challenges

- **Peace:** Submission prevents power struggles; Love ensures the leader acts in the best interest of the follower.
- **Honesty:** "Love rejoices in the truth," fostering open communication.
- **Respectful Submission:** It is not slavery but a voluntary support of leadership that brings order.
- **Support:** A loving husband provides and protects; a submitting wife supports and nurtures.
- **Intimacy:** When a wife feels loved, she opens up; when a husband feels respected, he engages. This cycle deepens intimacy.

5. Challenges of Post-Modernism for Christians

Concept: Post-modernism claims truth is relative ("My truth" vs. "Your truth") and rejects absolute moral standards.

Detailed Challenges:

1. **Skepticism of Grand Narratives:** They reject the "Big Story" of the Bible (Creation, Fall, Redemption) as just one of many myths.
2. **Undermining Biblical Authority:** If truth is relative, the Bible is just "good advice," not the authoritative Word of God.
3. **Pluralism:** The belief that "all roads lead to God." This challenges the Christian claim that Jesus is the *only* way.
4. **Erosion of Moral Authority:** If there is no absolute right or wrong, society cannot condemn sin (e.g., abortion or adultery become "personal choices").
5. **Rejection of Absolute Truth:** Truth becomes based on *feelings* (Subjectivity) rather than

facts or Scripture (Objectivity).

6. **Individualism:** The focus shifts from God's will to "what makes *me* happy."

 **Mnemonic: "S-U-P-E-R I"**

- **S** - Skepticism of narratives.
- **U** - Undermining Biblical Authority.
- **P** - Pluralism.
- **E** - Erosion of Moral Authority.
- **R** - Rejection of Absolute Truth.
- **I** - Individualism.

6. Classical Western Philosophers vs. Christian Ethics

1. Aristotle (Virtue Ethics)

- **His Teaching:**
 - **Goal:** *Eudaimonia* (Flourishing/Happiness) achieved by fulfilling human purpose.
 - **Method:** The *Golden Mean* (Virtue is the middle path between two vices, e.g., Courage is between Cowardice and Recklessness).
 - **Source:** Reason and observation.
- **Christian Response:**
 - **Affirmation:** Christians agree that character matters and habits (virtues) must be cultivated.
 - **Correction of Goal:** True flourishing is not just human happiness, but **Union with God** (Eternal Life).
 - **Correction of Source:** The standard is not human reason, but the **Character of Christ**.
 - **Correction of Means:** We cannot achieve virtue by habit alone because of *Sin*. We need **Divine Grace** and the **Holy Spirit**.

2. Plato (The Forms)

- **His Teaching:**
 - **Goal:** Knowledge of the "Form of the Good"—an abstract, perfect reality beyond the physical world.
 - **Method:** Intellectual discipline to ascend from the "Cave" (sensory world) to the light of Reason.
- **Christian Response:**
 - **Affirmation:** Christians agree there is an objective, absolute Truth beyond this physical world.
 - **Correction of Source:** The "Ultimate Good" is not an abstract concept, but a **Personal God (Yahweh)**.
 - **Correction of Means:** Truth is not found just by elite intellects thinking hard, but by **Revelation** (God showing Himself) and **Faith** accessible to everyone, not just philosophers.

 **Mnemonic: "A-V-G vs P-F-R"**

- **A-V-G:** Aristotle = Virtue/Reason -> Christian says **Grace**/Holy Spirit.
- **P-F-R:** Plato = Forms/Intellect -> Christian says **Revelation**/Relationship.

7. Principles for a Public Servant

Question: What principles guide a professional public servant?

Detailed Principles:

1. **Integrity and Honesty:**
 - Be truthful in all dealings.
 - **Avoid Conflicts of Interest:** Do not use the office for personal gain or to help friends/family.
 - Uphold ethical standards even when no one is watching.
2. **Accountability and Transparency:**
 - **Be Accountable:** Accept responsibility for decisions and submit to scrutiny.
 - **Transparency:** Keep processes open to the public (unless security dictates otherwise).
 - **Stewardship:** Use public funds efficiently; misuse is a breach of trust.
3. **Service and Impartiality:**
 - **Commitment:** Remember the role is to serve citizens, not rule them.
 - **Impartiality:** Treat all citizens equally regardless of tribe, politics, or status.
 - **Respect for Law:** Authority comes from the law, not personal power.
4. **Professionalism and Competence:**
 - **Standards:** Maintain a respectful demeanor and high work quality.
 - **Continuous Improvement:** Keep learning to adapt to new challenges.
 - **Non-Partisanship:** Remain neutral; implement policy rather than pushing political agendas.

 **Mnemonic: "P-A-I-S" (Public Servants)**

- **P** - Professionalism & Competence
- **A** - Accountability & Transparency
- **I** - Integrity & Honesty
- **S** - Service & Impartiality

10. Social Evils & Christian Response

A) Causes of Social Evils

- **Greed/Poverty:** The gap between rich and poor drives crime and corruption.
- **Breakdown of Family:** Divorce and absenteeism leave youth without moral compasses.
- **Media Influence:** Glorification of violence, sex, and materialism.
- **Corruption:** When leaders steal, it normalizes theft for everyone else.
- **Secularism:** Removing God from public life removes the fear of divine judgment.

 **Mnemonic: "G-B M-C-S" (Greed, Breakdown, Media, Corruption, Secularism)**

B) Your Contribution as a Christian Ethics Student

- **Role Modeling:** Be the example of integrity in your class/workplace.
- **Advocacy:** Use your voice to speak for the voiceless (orphans, poor).
- **Counseling/Guidance:** Use biblical principles to advise those struggling.
- **Education:** Teach others the value of ethics to change the mindset of the next

generation.

11. Roles of the Church in Society

Question: Discuss 5 roles with examples.

1. **Charity/Welfare:** The church provides a safety net for the vulnerable.
 - *Example:* **Watoto Child Care Ministries** caring for orphans.
2. **Health Services:** The church has historically built the best hospitals.
 - *Example:* **Mengo Hospital** (founded by missionaries).
3. **Education:** Providing quality education grounded in values.
 - *Example:* **Uganda Christian University (UCU)**.
4. **Moral Guidance:** The church acts as the "conscience" of the nation, preaching against corruption and violence.
5. **Peace Building/Reconciliation:** Church leaders often mediate in political or tribal conflicts to restore peace.

 **Mnemonic: "C-H-E-M-P" (The Church is a CHAMP)**

- **C** - Charity
- **H** - Health
- **E** - Education
- **M** - Moral Guidance
- **P** - Peace Building